



RFC 10023 EXPLAINED

A Domain Is Registered. But Is It Really Unavailable?

How one small DNS record turns a dead end into a deal — by Marco Davids, SIDN Labs

There is a small but surprisingly important piece of information that DNS does not normally tell you. You query a domain and discover it's already registered. From a registrar's availability checker, that's usually the end of the story. But it may not be.

The domain may be parked. It may be unused. It may be held by an investor who is perfectly happy to sell it. So there are really two different questions:

Is this domain name registered? — Is this domain name obtainable?

DNS, WHOIS and RDAP are good at answering the first. Until now, there was no simple, standardized way to answer the second — that's what RFC 10023 fixes.

The “digital for-sale sign”

The idea is deliberately boring: a DNS TXT record at a reserved name.

```
_for-sale.example.com.  IN  TXT  "v=FORSALE1;furi=https://example.com/sale"
```

The record can carry a URI, an asking price, or plain text — added or removed by the domain holder at any time, without touching the domain's normal DNS operation. No new protocol, no new port, no registry-wide database. Just: `$ dig TXT _for-sale.example.com`

Why put this in DNS?

DNS isn't a marketplace, and it doesn't need to become one. But domain holders already control their own zone data — which makes DNS a surprisingly good place for a simple statement of intent. The record is not a transaction, not proof of ownership, not a binding offer. It simply says:

“This registered domain is available for purchase.”

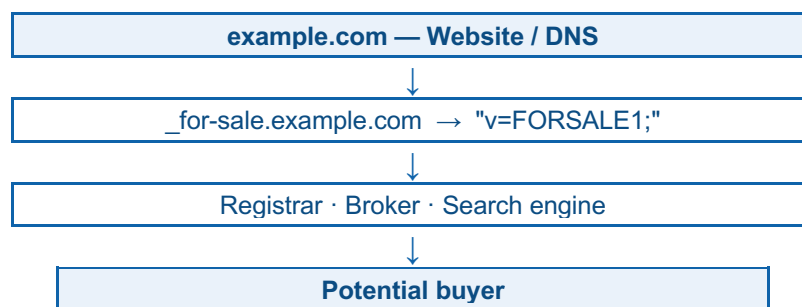
But isn't this just helping domainers?

Fair objection — the domain aftermarket has a complicated reputation. But the alternative isn't a world without domain trading. It's a world where a holder who no longer wants a domain simply lets it expire, and someone with better tooling catches it milliseconds later. The former holder gets nothing. A _for-sale signal moves that transaction from an opaque “let it drop and see who catches it” game towards an explicit “the owner wants to sell it” arrangement — without eliminating investors, brokers, or drop-catching.

One tiny record, one useful bit of information

A registered domain isn't necessarily unavailable — “registered” has always been a poor proxy for “not obtainable.” RFC 10023 gives domain holders a way to say:

“Don't wait for me to drop this domain. I actually want to sell it.”



The domain is registered. The DNS says it is for sale. Now the Internet can know the difference.

Ready to publish your own _for-sale record?

Read the full RFC at rfc-editor.org/rfc/rfc10023.html, explore tooling and examples at github.com/SIDN/ForSale-RFC10023, or get in touch with SIDN Labs directly.